

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

A SAD RETREAT

The address of the Badals in New Delhi is set to change, as the estate department has asked former Union minister Harsimrat Kaur Badal to vacate her 12, Safdarjung Road bungalow, which has been with the family for 25 years. Allotted to Shiromani Akali Dal patron Parkash Singh Badal, it then went to his son Sukhbir when he was Union minister and from 2014 to Sukhbir's wife Harsimrat after she joined PM Modi's cabinet. The Badals join those, like Jayant Singh, Meira Kumar and Chirag Paswan, who were forced to vacate long-occupied government accommodation after losing public mandate and positions. Out of the NDA government, Harsimrat has been allotted a smaller house at 76, Lodhi Estate. The SAD's waning influence is thus reflected in the Badals' losing the legacy bungalow.

CAPITAL MATTER



Farmers agitating for the retention of Amaravati as Andhra Pradesh's capital city pose a fresh challenge to CM **Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy's** plan of three 'decentralised' capitals (Visakhapatnam and Kurnool being the other two). A few hundred farmers who had given land for Amaravati will set out on a 600 km march on September 12 and end it on November 17. As they would have passed through Visakhapatnam, the planned administrative capital, Jagan, wary of violence, asked the police to refuse them permission. Jagan should learn from the Centre's bitter experience with the 2021 kisan agitation over new farm laws and handle them with kid gloves.

NEW PERSUADERS

With the Congress presidential election scheduled for October 17, desperation is growing among Gandhi family loyalists to persuade **Rahul Gandhi** to contest. Most veterans hope to use the time Rahul will spend with them during the 150-day-long Bharat Jodo Yatra to convince him to head the party again. There were outsiders also who joined in—Bihar CM Nitish Kumar and Tamil Nadu CM M.K. Stalin. Both Nitish, who met Rahul in Delhi recently, and Stalin, who attended the Yatra's launch on September 7 in his home state, asked Rahul to reconsider his decision to stay away from the Congress leadership.



ANI

–Kaushik Deka with Anilesh S. Mahajan, Amarnath K. Menon, Kiran D. Tare and Rahul Noronha



POLITICS, A BALLGAME

Valanka Alemao, a Trinamool Congress member and CEO of Churchill Brothers, one of India's most successful football clubs, on September 2 became the first woman to be elected executive committee member of the All India Football Federation (AIFF) in its 85-year history. It did not come easy; 10 members had challenged her nomination by the Goa Football Association. Now, with AIFF president and ex-footballer Kalyan Chaubey of the BJP as colleague, her father Churchill Alemao, former Goa CM, might get a chance to cosy up to the BJP to stay relevant in state politics. Valanka herself lost the 2017 and 2022 Goa polls.



In Mama's Chair

Rumours of Madhya Pradesh CM **Shivraj Singh Chouhan's** replacement are back for the nth time, triggered by his exit from the BJP's parliamentary board in August. Soon after, a Union minister from Bundelkhand claimed he was being considered for the post of CM. The buzz grew stronger when Union minister Jyotiraditya Scindia called on Shivraj's rival, the BJP's Kailash Vijayvargiya in Indore. Political analysts have started studying Chouhan's 'body language'. In fact, the rumours have been so frequent that Chouhan himself is unfazed by them.